

Humanity's Indomitable Drive For Change

And What we can do to Reignite it

Mike Sosteric

for

The Peace Table

<https://medium.com/the-peace-table>

Version 1.0

Revolutions—true revolutions—do not emerge from the subterranean depths of consciousness fully formed. They always start as an idea, a powerful vision that transforms thinking and impels action. As noted previously, Humanistic psychologist Abraham Maslow had such a vision. On December 8, 1941, the day after Pearl Harbor, while the world burned with literal war, he experienced a vision that redirected his entire intellectual life (Hoffman 1999). He saw a Peace Table where humanity gathered to understand itself, to heal, and to finally break the cycles of violence that had defined civilization for so long. A psychology not of pathology and control, but one devoted to the full actuation of Human Potential. A psychology that could not only end war but that would shortly bring about what Maslow called Eupsychia, or the Good Society (Maslow 1961). A happy society of happy people who are happily busy realizing their full potential. Utopia, by any other name.

This wasn't the only vision he had. "One night," while he was all alone at a furniture store where he was working as a part-time night watchman, he experienced a profound breakthrough of awe and admiration for the author of a book he was reading, *Folkways*. "It was a kind of cold chill and hair-

standing-on-end peak-experience.” He was “not merely happy,” he said, he “felt a sense of the uncanny and of littleness, incapability, and the like.” From this experience Maslow made what “would have been called 500 years ago” a vow, a resolution: “to do like Sumner....to make a similar contribution to philosophy, psychology, and anthropology.” By Maslow’s account it was a transformative experience, one where his “ethnocentrism dropped away like old clothes” and he “became a citizen of the world.” If I had been in King Arthur’s court, I suppose that I would have kept vigil beside my sword and before an altar all night long. That was exactly the spirit of it. In any case, that’s what I’ve done with my life. (Maslow 1996:20)

I don’t know who he was bowing to that night, God, an ancestor, Archangel Michael, an abstract idea of service (most likely given his materialist tendencies), but the grandeur of the experience and the solemnity of his feelings are quite clear. Like Sir Lancelot of the Round Table, he devoted his life to the service of humanity, to making a big splash, to creating something really big.

What did he do? He decided to develop a reconceptualization of humanity, a new narrative seed from which we would build a “new image of [humanity], of society, of nature, of science, of ultimate values, of philosophy, etc., etc.” He wanted this new image to be applied to all areas (political, economic, social, institutional, etc.) of life. In his own words he wanted to create an integrated, holistic humanistic *Weltanschauung* (Maslow 1970). Basically, he wanted to change the way we think about ourselves and he wanted to do that so humanity could finally build Eupsychia, a good society.

It sounds grandiose, even delusional, but you may be surprised to find that it is not that unusual. This sort of grand, devote-my-life-to-a-mission-to-transform-humanity is a lot more common than you think, especially among those with the privilege of following their visions. For example, sociological founding father **Auguste Comte** (very privileged) tried to do exactly the same thing as Maslow with his expansive “positive philosophy,” “positive politics” “*Catechism of Positivism; or, Summary Exposition of the Universal Religion*” (Comte 1852) way back in the 19th century. I don’t know if he had a vision, but he definitely thought he could build a philosophical system that could ground a better world. I think he was ready to implement it too. On the opening page of his Catechism he claims just that.

In the name of the Past and of the Future, the servants of Humanity—both its philosophical and practical servants—come forward to claim as their due the general direction of this

world. Their object is, to constitute at length a real Providence, in all departments—moral, intellectual, and material. (Comte 1852).

Oscar Ichazo, a Bolivian philosopher, tried to do the same thing. He tried to build an empirically grounded system that could put humanity on the right track. He spoke of the “Challenge to Change” (Fox 1982) and considered himself to be the “Root of a New Tradition” (De Christopher 1982). You can’t get any clearer than that.¹

And this is just two. There is more. Way more, I feel, though for certain some research is required here.

Was Maslow’s mission ambitious?

Absolutely. Maslow wanted to change the direction of humanity.

Was he successful?

Did he accomplish his goal?

No.

Well...

No, but with a bit of yes.

No, he and his humanistic colleagues didn’t change the way we see ourselves and they didn’t change the direction of society. That’s sad.

But, yes, big yes, magnificent yes, he and his colleagues did succeed in building the theoretical foundation for Eupsychia. At least, all the notes were there (Hoffman 1996, 1999). This foundation consisted, I believe, of three pillars, Humanistic Psychology, Transpersonal Psychology, and a third, arguably nascent, **Eupsychian Psychology**.² These three psychologies would have informed his magnum contribution, the Psychology of the Peace Table.

He said it himself. He acknowledged the progress they had made.

There is now available a new conception, of a higher possibility, of the healthy society.

There are **tools now available to judge and compare societies**. One society can be judged

1 Somebody needs to do an article, or a thesis, or even a dissertation on Oscar Ichazo. I bet it would be fascinating.

2 <https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Eupsychia>

to be better than another society, or healthier or possessing more 'growth-fostering-potential.' **We can talk about the value of the society, or the function of the society**—that is, the greatest coming to fulfillment of the people in the society" (Maslow 1969:7: Emphasis added).

Notice Maslow's statement here. He says we, and by we he means psychologists, are advanced enough now that we can meaningfully and empirically talk about the value and the function of society.

That's a pretty big statement when you think about it. It's even bigger when you realize that Maslow felt he had the answer. It's a massive cognitive mind flop when finally realize that it is just simple common sense.

Society's Function is to fulfill human needs so that humans can reach their full potential.

Society's Value is derived exclusively from its ability to meet [Essential Needs](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Essential_Needs).³

Better societies are the ones that do a better job at fulfilling these needs.

This is not rocket science.

This is peace table psychology.

With this Maslow's Pearl Harbor vision is realized.

With this, his sacred vow fulfilled.

And then....

And then?

Nothing.

The whole thing just fizzled out and now we are stuck exactly where we were back in the sixties, only with a much greater technical mastery of things and ***much*** bigger crises to face (Albert 2024). It's frightening to think that no government seems to have a plan, except maybe China.

It didn't have to be this way.

3 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Essential_Needs

Maslow died prematurely, that's true, after which the entire humanistic movement fizzled. But it wasn't because a great hero died. It is because it "lost its power," as Elkins said (2009). Not quite stillborn, but definitely stunted.

So what happened?

For one, as Maslow himself pointed out, it was completely ignored by a "disgusting" corporate media.

...whose subscriptions I am going to cancel: *The Atlantic Monthly*, *Harper*, *The Saturday Review* (that is the best of them, but it's not very good), and the *New York Review of Books* (which is definitely the worst). All of these mass-circulation periodicals reveal the entire intellectual establishment's alienation and its total lack of knowledge about the emerging new intellectual synthesis. I was thinking this morning: Where are the great names from among the humanists today? These magazines never even mention them. Where are Carl Rogers, Gordon Allport, Henry Murray, and Gardner Murphy, let alone the younger people like Michael Murphy.

For two, again, as Maslow pointed out, it was resisted within the academy for irrational, emotional and pathological reasons. People didn't like that the humanists were talking about "mystical" and "transcendental" experiences and being open and honest and loving and such. They were prejudiced, dogmatic, and overly pessimistic, I would add indoctrinated, having "a narrow rationalistic attitude" which Maslow's psychologically oriented mind considered a "defense against being flooded by emotion" (Maslow 1962:15). It hits intuitively.

For three, as Elkins (2009) has noted, it was systematically marginalized and defunded, "murdered," he said. The vision snuffed out, the vow relinquished, the emancipatory drive all but snuffed out.

Of course, psychological and political factors were not the only impediments. Let us be clear. Maslow and his colleagues were attempting a monumental theoretical and practical feat. They wanted an entirely new philosophical and psychological foundation. They had the brains and the motivation. What they lacked was advanced [Knowledge Technology](https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Knowledge_Technology).⁴ The technology they were working with was positively primitive. All they had was a typewriter. And it wasn't just their writing tool that was primitive. Their communication technology was as well. If a posse member wasn't in the room, you

4 https://spiritwiki.lightningpath.org/index.php/Knowledge_Technology

had to either call them on the phone, something that could get quite expensive if you were calling long distance, or overseas. Failing that you either send a letter or you hopped on a boat (later a plane) to go talk to them in person.

Consequently,

- **Theoretical development was slow**, for obvious reasons. As editing tools, Typewriters are simply not. On them, writing is slow and cumbersome. If you need to change a word, you have to retype the whole thing. In addition, with only snail mail and expensive long distance, connection and interpersonal communication was not what it is today, I can tell you that. You were a lot more isolated, globally speaking, back then.
- **Theoretical development was choppy and uneven**, again, for obvious reasons. Maslow only had a typewriter to work with. Print methods provided knowledge records inscribed in granite by today's standards. Evolving theory from print sources is like trying to swim forward in molasses.
- **Theory tended to ossify**. No better example of this is in the persistence of that disgusting pyramid of needs, a pyramid which, given Maslow's later more advanced understanding of needs and motivation, is an embarrassingly inadequate representation (Sosteric and Ratkovic in press).
- **Theory remained hidden and esoteric**, hiding in journals and books that only the educated would find.

Consider the fact that Maslow modified his needs theory throughout his career, adding many different needs to his 1943 draft formulations (Maslow 1943b, 1943a). Unfortunately, he could never go back and change what he wrote. Consequently, he had to bury his revisions in esoteric scholarly journals, cumbersome books, personal chit chat (Hoffman 1999), and unpublished papers.⁵ It was very inefficient. You can imagine, as I will in the next article of this series "What is a Knowledge System" how many problems that caused (Sosteric planned). You can also imagine how much better it might have been, both for theoretical development *and* future researchers, if he could have gone back and

⁵ A very big thank you should go out to Dr. Edward Hoffman for his work in not only discussing, distributing, and helping to advance Maslow's unpublished thoughts and words, e.g. (Hoffman 1996, 1999), but in carrying the candle that has maintained this light (Hoffman 2023).

presented the finished version right there at the beginning. It violates our temporal sensibilities true, but so what? If we're gonna save the planet we need to learn to think outside the boxes that box us in.

Who knows what Maslow and his colleagues might have accomplished if they had even just a word processor to use. Imagine if they had modern technologies, blogging platforms, wikis, and the like. Imagine if he had generative AI to help him analyze and systematize. Imagine if Maslow could have spoken not only to his students a Brandeis, but in print or even in real time(!) to people all over the world.

I can imagine we'd be a lot farther along than we are today had Maslow had those things.

But, like I said, it fizzled.

Which is pretty tragic when you think about it.

So I guess as we face down the accelerating poly-crisis that threatens to overwhelm and destroy human civilization the question now becomes, have we missed our chance. Are we, as a species, cooked?

I'm going to remain hopeful.

I'm going to say no.

As a species we didn't have what we needed back in the 1960s, but we do now. Not only do we have the administrative, technological, and financial capacity required to create a globally coherent Eupsychian society, we have the advanced knowledge technology and the advanced knowledge tools to help conceptualize and manifest that society.

We will talk more about this next time.

Until then,

Welcome Home.

References

- Albert, Michael J. 2024. *Navigating the Polycrisis: Mapping the Futures of Capitalism and the Earth*. MIT Press.
- Comte, Auguste. 1852. *The Catechism of Positivism; or, Summary Exposition of the Universal Religion*. London: John Chapman.
- De Christopher, Dorothy. 1982. "I Am the Root of a New Tradition." Pp. 129–54 in *Interviews with Oscar Ichazo*. New York: Arica Institute Press.
- Elkins, David. 2009. "Why Humanistic Psychology Lost Its Power and Influence in American Psychology." *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* 49(1):267–91. doi:10.1177/0010.1177/0022167808323575.
- Fox, Alfie. 1982. "The Challenge to Change." Pp. 156–81 in *Interviews with Oscar Ichazo*. New York: Arica Institute Press.
- Hoffman, Edward, ed. 1996. *Future Visions*. London: Sage Publications.
- Hoffman, Edward. 1999. *The Right to Be Human*. New York: McGraw-Hill.
- Hoffman, Edward. 2023. "Introduction to the Special Issue on Eupsychia." *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* 63(4):435–37. doi:10.1177/00221678221101959.
- Maslow, A. H. 1969. "The Farthest Reaches of Human Nature." *The Journal of Transpersonal Psychology* 1(1):1–9.
- Maslow, Abraham H. 1943a. "A Theory of Human Motivation." *Psychological Review* 50(4):370–96. doi:10.1037/h0054346.
- Maslow, Abraham H. 1943b. "Preface to Motivation Theory." *Psychosomatic Medicine* 5(1):85–92. doi:https://doi.org/10.1097/00006842-194301000-00012.
- Maslow, Abraham H. 1961. "Eupsychia—The Good Society." *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* 1(2):1.
- Maslow, Abraham H. 1962. "Lessons from the Peak-Experiences." *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* 2(1):9–18. doi:10.1177/002216786200200102.
- Maslow, Abraham H. 1970. *Motivation and Personality (2nd Ed.)*. New York: Harper & Row.
- Maslow, Abraham H. 1996. "My Early Revelations About Culture and Personality." Pp. 19–21 in *Future Visions: The Unpublished Papers of Abraham Maslow*, edited by E. Hoffman. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications.
- Sosteric, Mike. planned. "What Is a Knowledge System." *The Peace Table*.

Sosteric, Mike, and Gina Ratkovic. in press. “Eupsychian Theory I: Reclaiming Maslow and Rejecting The Pyramid—The Seven Essential Needs.” <https://www.academia.edu/44676359/>.